

-
-
-
-
-

Chapter 10

Drinks Telesales Overview



Introduction

In an increasingly competitive sales situation there is greater emphasis being placed on proactive selling. One of the most potent weapons in this area is the telephone. It is no longer enough to wait for customers to call or write with the details of an order. Everything that can be done to get the order must be done. But telephone connect time is expensive, both in terms of the actual connection charge and the use of trained sales office personnel. It is essential, therefore, that each and every telephone call be as productive as possible. The economics of making the calls and supporting the sales staff with a sophisticated computer system must be measured and evaluated.

There is a wide definition of a Telesales module ranging from cold calling or telemarketing to the taking of an expected order from an existing customer for an agreed list of items.

Clearly the different types of call are conducted in a different manner. There are, however, certain common elements of support that could be provided by a computer system.

What Does Telesales Do?

The objective of the Drinks Telesales module is to provide support to the Sales Operator such that the process is completed in the minimum time with the greatest accuracy and the least disruption to the Customer and Sales Office. In order to achieve this the dialogue should take place in a structured fashion, ideally where the Buyer and Seller are using the same “script”.

Obviously this latter condition is not possible in a cold call situation; however, all the support information must be readily available to the Seller. In particular, the response time from the computer system should be such that it will not normally cause the Seller to request the Buyer to pause before proceeding. While such performance is ultimately a function of computer resources, the greatest care has been taken to ensure that screen response time is optimised for the normal method of Telesales operation.

All such systems require a list of calls to be made on any particular day. Typically this list is divided amongst the Telesales operators. Some of the calls have specific times at which they should be made, others only have the date.

Supervisory functions are required to manage and re-assign the work to be done. The Telesales module contains the following procedures:

Maintenance Functions

- Company Details.
- Operator Profiles.
- Buying Lists.
- Customer Contacts.
- Call Profiles.
- Delivery Profiles.
- Sales Prompts.
- Promotions.
- Item Families.
- Reason Descriptions.
- Cases/Pallets Conversion.

Processes

- Make Outgoing Calls.
- Take Incoming Calls.
- Manage Call Lists.
- Generate Call Lists.

Reporting and Enquiry

- Enquire on Call Lists.

- Enquire on a Whole Order.
- Enquire on Availability of Stock.
- Enquire on Promotions.
- Enquire on Call Planning Details.
- Enquire on Call Management details.
- Print Customer Details.
- Print Sales Prompts.
- Print Operator Profiles.
- Print Reason Codes.
- Print Promotion Details.
- Print Buying Lists.
- Print Daily Call Lists.
- Print Daily Operator Extracts.
- Print Operator Performance Details.

Telesales Style

Three distinct styles of Telesales are supported by the module:

- Telesales.
- Planned Delivery.
- Telemarketing.

Telesales

Telesales is where an expected order is being taken from a known customer with an established buying pattern. The module generates the call list for the day, identifying the sales operator, the time and the sales contacts. When a call is selected, the customer's buying list is displayed. Along with the list of items, the immediate ordering history is displayed. By pressing a **Function** Key, it is possible to replace the order history with price information. The module enables the entry of all the order information and on pressing **Enter** proceed to the next screen. At the end of the entry of order line information the module will display an order summary. Following the closing of the order the remaining calls are then displayed, allowing the next customer to be selected.

Planned Delivery

Planned delivery is a particular form of order entry. In this style of order entry the customer quotes his current stock levels. The module has previously calculated the average weekly demand.

From this information the quantity that should be ordered is calculated to ensure minimum stock holding with little risk of running out. This is automatically entered as the order quantity. The order closing procedures are the same as for standard Telesales. Provision is made for the adjustment of the order quantity if necessary.

Telemarketing

Telemarketing is defined as order entry to support the contacting of customers where the chances of taking an order are very much reduced. There is however, the requirement to create a call diary which is supported by the same facilities of call back and reschedule. Having categorised the account it may be appropriate to display a target list of items for that type of account.

It can be seen, therefore, that the process of referring to a call diary, selecting an account and then displaying a definable list of items can support a wide range of Telesales activities.

Relationships to Other Modules

The Telesales Module is a fully standardised product, and is one of the Base Drinks Modules.

The following Modules are pre-requisites to the operation of Telesales:

- Drinks Sales Order Processing.
- Drinks Inventory Management.

If planned delivery is to be used:

- Drinks Sales Analysis.

The objective of the Drinks Telesales Module is to build standard Sales Orders. All of the standard sales order functions can then be used to service the order. This includes batch allocation, picking, despatch and invoicing, as well as the full range of enquiries and reports. As part of the recording of the sales order, the module will perform a check on available stock and highlight any shortage conditions. If Planned Delivery is used, then it is necessary to have access to the sales history of a customer so that the average usages for the customer can be calculated; this is derived from the Sales Analysis Database.

Module Configuration

As with all the modules, Drinks Telesales can be operated for a number of companies, the characteristics of each is maintained on a control file. Before a company can be set-up, however, Drinks Sales Order Processing and Drinks Inventory Management must have been installed and configured for the company. The control information may then be maintained.

This can be divided into the following classes of data:

Company standard policy controls for:

- Telesales type.
- Contact types.
- Operator performance and rest periods.
- Buying lists.
- Target for action messages.
- Request for performance statistics.

Text:

- Operators.
- Call Profiles.
- Buying Lists.
- Contacts.
- Delivery Profiles.
- Promotions.

Description Identities for:

- Promotion types.
- Delivery routes.

It is also possible to exercise some control over the presentation of data in the all important order recording process. This is done by taking the option for "Presentation Design" from the Company Maintenance screen. Control over such things as the display of the date and the standard concatenation of item number and description is provided.

Maintenance of Reference Data

Much of the primary data has already been set up as part of the Sales Order Processing and Inventory Management modules. There is, however, additional information which must be entered in order to obtain the maximum benefit from the module. There are a number of common features in the way in which this data is maintained, these are:

- The standard item and customer search routines have been adopted.
- The module makes the minimum use of 'codes' and where they are employed a prompt is always available to assist in selecting the correct one.
- Selection is normally from a displayed list or by the entry of a code.

Information for the following may be maintained:

- Operator Profiles.
- Buying lists.
- Customer contacts.
- Call profiles.
- Sales prompts.
- Promotions.
- Item families.
- Reason descriptions.
- Cases/Pallets Conversion.

Operators

All persons who are involved in using the Drinks Telesales facilities for taking and managing calls must be identified to the module. The details which can be recorded include name and module user ID, as well as standard times; for calls, rest period and the working day, and a statement of the type of Telesales calls in which the operator is proficient. The record will also contain the degree of freedom the operator is allowed to change the sequence in which calls are to be made or to divert them to another operator.

Buying List

One aim of the Drinks Telesales Module is to provide the operator with a list of items to discuss with a Customer. In many companies it is possible to have a standard list of items which can be used as a basis for a call to most Customers. However, having agreed that the objective of the module is to fit as closely as possible to the Customers' requirements and, therefore, to minimise the call time, it is inevitable that, for certain accounts, it is advantageous to use bespoke lists. The module provides for the creation and maintenance of such lists both by direct entry or by copying part or all of existing lists. Not only is it possible to create a list at the appropriate level, but also to automatically build the description of the item that is displayed to the operator. Alternatively the

customer's item number could be entered and maintained on a Customer's Buying List rather than the in-house item number.

If a Customer's Call profile identifies 'History' buying lists, then the default buying list for the customer is reduced to only those items that have a sales history for that customer. The panels for this history buying list are then sequenced into product groups using the item's Price Sequence code.

Customer Contacts

The module provides for the maintenance of customer contacts. Any number of such contacts can be created. As well as the contact name and details, telephone extension number and comments can be stored. When a call profile is being created, the 'Prime' contact for that call is selected from the list of contacts.

Call Profiles

The whole basis of the Drinks Telesales module is to establish patterns or diaries for the calling of customers. There are a number of attributes which can be recorded which are necessary to control the frequency and nature of the calls. They can be conveniently grouped under the following five headings:

- How to contact - telephone, fax, telex numbers.
- Who to contact - preferred or prime contact.
- Whose responsibility - sales operator.
- Nature of contact - buying list, type of call, pallet or case quantities and panel type.
- When to contact - time of the day, days of the week and weekly frequency.

Full additional text facilities are provided.

Delivery Profiles

In order to get the maximum benefit from a Telesales module, it can be used to synchronise the customer contact with the expected delivery pattern. In this way, the company can make the best use of its transport expenditure and the probability of the customer receiving the goods when expected is increased.

As with call profiles the information can be grouped:

- How to contact - telephone, telex, fax.
- Who to contact - primary contact.
- When delivery is convenient - times of the day, days of the week and weekly frequency.
- Geography - delivery route, drop sequence number.

Full additional text facilities are provided.

Sales Prompts

In any sales environment, particularly where there is controlled contact with the customer, it is appropriate that certain key reminders are frequently presented to the operator. This might relate to stock shortages or surpluses, pending price changes or general messages. Each message is controlled by an effectivity date. The messages are displayed one at a time, in sequence, at the top of the

diary management and order taking screens, so that each time the **Enter** key is pressed, the prompt changes.

Promotions

Sales Promotions is a very large, complex and varied subject. This module does not attempt to support and manage all aspects of promotions. It does, however, seek to provide the basic recording of when they take place and the scope and nature of the promotion. The following information can be recorded:

- The promotion type.
- The dates when it is operational.
- What it is called and its promotion number.
- The target increase in sales.
- The constraints.
- Items which are being promoted, or 'award' items which are being offered.
- A specific customer or customer classification.

If an item is to be substituted by a promotional item, this can be defined on the promotion. This can be used to affect the replacement at order entry if the promotion is accepted.

If an item is being offered as a Free of Charge 'Award' when certain qualifying items are ordered, this can be defined as a Freeloader or Loyalty Promotion scheme, with the awards being offered automatically during Order Entry.

Item Families

The Planned Delivery style requires that a number of items are linked together into an item family for the purpose of analysing sales in generic markets. This is achieved by creating a 'family' like a 'Bill of Materials'.

For example: A family could have a base item of 'beer' and any number of promotion items or 'types'. All items both base and promotion must be complete items defined to the Drinks Inventory Management Module. Families can be set up and maintained directly or are automatically created by defining a promotion with a promotional item.

Reason Descriptions

One purpose of the Drinks Telesales Module is to set objectives for the Sales Operators and then to exercise a degree of control and measurement over their performance. If an operator is unable, either by typing in a code or selecting one from a list, to achieve the expected action at the expected time they are required to give a reason. Reason codes appropriate for the company can be set-up and maintained as required.

Cases/Pallets Conversion

This function is used to set the number of cases per pallet for a particular item/customer combination, overriding the relationship established for the item on the Inventory Item Master file. This information is used to structure the input and displayed quantities when a call profile dictates that the order is to be taken in pallet quantities.

Generate Call Lists

This is a batch run which will run on request. It will normally be run at the end of each working day to prepare the call list up to a specified date. The following actions can be performed as part of this run:

- Make an entry in the call list for all call profiles with a date, less than or equal to the specified date of the run.
- Generate a skeleton order based upon the nominated buying list for the call profile.
- Generate the prices for the customer/items on the buying list.
- Generate order history for the specified number of orders.

The first two of these will always be performed whilst pricing and order history is done if requested. The defaults for their inclusion in the run is on the company control file, but in order to balance the work load between call list generation and response times, different combinations can be tried by changing the run time parameters.

Manage Call Lists

Options are provided to manage the Call Lists. Each operator is set up with an authority level reflecting the options they are authorised to use. The following authority levels are available:

- 0 - The Operator must take the next call in sequence.
- 1 - The Operator may take any call next.
- 2 - The Operator may amend the time of the call.
- 3 - The Operator may change who is to make a call.

Operators will also have authority to option below their level, i.e. a user authorised to option 2 also has access to option 1. There are two lists created, both are sequenced by the Operator and Date. However, the timed calls are added to one and the untimed to the other. The Call List is displayed on the screen with timed calls at the top and untimed at the bottom.

The module will take the average call time for the operator, add it to the current time and if no timed calls are due by the calculated time, it will select an untimed call. This calculation is performed each time the screen is selected or the Refresh option is taken. Similarly each time the Call Selection Screen is displayed one of the Sales Prompts is displayed. Only an operator with an authority level of '3' can enter the call list of another operator to re-organise and redistribute it. If a call is selected but contact is not completed the operator is able to request call back at a specified time.

Record Order Details

Once a Customer has been selected the module will enter the appropriate style of order entry:

- Telesales.
- Planned Delivery.
- Telemarketing.

The top part of the screen will contain key customer information including contact name and extension number. The left hand side of the screen will contain the

item identification. For each item the Telesales function is able to create a 30 character identifier made up of item number and description as they wish. Order details are entered in a column; either order quantity or current stock level in the case of Planned Delivery.

On the right hand side is the previous order data for Telesales, the average order information for Planned Delivery or price data. Function keys will switch from the price screen to the History/Average screen and back. The objective of these screens is to enable the order details to be entered extremely quickly, therefore, pressing **Enter** will normally proceed to the next screen.

At the end of the item screens the module will present a summary which will:

- Display the details of the order lines taken. In the case of planned delivery it will include the calculated order quantity.
- Display the price and discount.
- Allow the entry of additional items.
- Allow the entry of promotional items.
- Perform credit check.
- Demand entry of customer order entry reference.
- Quote the order number.
- If additional charges are required an additional screen can be displayed.
- Allow entry of order date and due delivery date for the order.
- The free stock is tested to confirm that despatch can be made.
- Provide for confirmation of the next call details.

In the case of Telemarketing the buying lists can also be displayed. This includes the description of the list, e.g. Small Breweries - Nettles. The list need not be static - it might, for example, contain those items which should be pushed to a particular market sector today.

Create Sales Orders

The recording of order details will update an order work file that will have been created by a previous batch run. This will provide maximum speed and security. The next step is to create the information required to allow allocation, picking and despatch to be handled by standard Drinks Sales Order Processing functions. This update exists as a 'sleeper' in the Drinks Telesales sub-system and, when active, creates an order on the Sales Order Processing Database.

Work Planning

The module will display in bar chart form the work to be done by Operator by day. This will include time for the standard rest period. This enquiry will enable class three operators to re-plan work.

Performance Analysis

If chosen as a company control option, performance statistics are recorded. The elapsed time for each stage of the order taking cycle and the number of lines taken is recorded. The performance analysis report will then give Operator Performance information at summary or detail level between a range of dates.

Using Drinks Telesales

To use Drinks Telesales careful planning and preparation are required. Your existing Telesales procedures and data need to be transferred to the module. Consideration should also be given to improvements which could be made to current procedures by making full use of the Drinks Telesales modules' capabilities.

When Drinks Telesales is installed, four major areas must be considered.

- Have the prerequisite modules been installed and if so are they set up in a way which is suitable for the operation of Drinks Telesales?
- How will the functions and facilities of the Drinks Telesales module be used to enhance the selling activity of the company?
- Has the operation of Drinks Telesales been discussed with customers?
- Have the operators of the module had adequate education?

Relationship to Other Modules

Drinks Telesales relies heavily on the data held in other modules and indeed its objective is to generate orders in a standard form within Drinks Sales Order Processing. This module must therefore be installed and all its prerequisites and conditions must be satisfied.

The two character company code in Drinks Telesales identifies to which Drinks Sales Order Processing, Drinks Inventory Management, Accounts Receivable and Drinks Sales Analysis company it is linked.

A number of Drinks Telesales functions depend directly on data held in other modules. These are:

- While an order is being taken previous order history data can be displayed to the operator. This is extracted from previous Telesales orders on the Drinks Sales Order Processing database.
- The pricing and discounting information used in Drinks Telesales is retrieved from Drinks Sales Order Processing.
- The customer information such as supplying depot, price list, discount list and currency is retrieved from Drinks Sales Order Processing.
- Stock levels used in sourcing and availability checks are from the Drinks Inventory Management module.
- Data from Drinks Sales Analysis is used to calculate average weekly sales.

How will the Drinks Telesales Module be used?

Drinks Telesales is designed to record order requirements, quickly, while holding a conversation with a customer over the telephone. To achieve this a pre-agreed list of items is presented to the operator to offer to the customer, the only entry required being the ordered quantity. The module offers three variations on this basic theme. It is a primary requirement that these methods are fully understood so that the appropriate technique can be used with each customer. The following questions must be addressed:

- Which style of Drinks Telesales is used for each customer?
- Will standard buying lists be created, will they be customer specific, and should they be based on 'sales history'?
- Will operators work in small groups on a list of customers or will they each have their own customer list?
- Will the module be used to time and record the performance of each operator?

All of the above are fully discussed in the body of this product information.

Discussion with Customers

Throughout the manual, speed and accuracy is emphasised as a key objective of Drinks Telesales. In order to gain the maximum benefit from the module it is important that customers understand the nature of the dialogue you plan to hold over the telephone. They should understand that you intend to sell from a list and perhaps should have a copy of the list. If the Planned Delivery technique is to be used they must understand that they are expected to give current stock levels and they must have complete confidence in the re-order level algorithm used by the module.

Are the Operators trained?

As with all systems that directly impact your relationships with your customers it is vital that the only change they see is improvement. It is essential therefore that operators are trained to use the module. This is one module where it is both practical and desirable to introduce a pilot scheme with a small number of carefully selected customers.

Basic Data

Having decided how you will use Drinks Telesales in conjunction with other modules and the companies you will use, you need to plan and implement the setting up of the additional data required. The main elements you will need to create are:

- Company Profile.
- Operator Profiles.
- Buying Lists.
- Customer Contacts.
- Call Profiles.
- Promotions.
- Reason Codes.

Company Profile

The Drinks Telesales module will make use of information held on the Drinks Sales Order Processing and Drinks Inventory Management company profiles. Additional information is also required.

Defaults for the operation of Drinks Telesales:

- Type of order (telesales, telemarketing, planned delivery).
- Buying list.
- Time of pricing.
- Stock availability check.
- Names to be used in dates, e.g. January, February etc and Monday, Tuesday etc.
- Formatting at the order line entry screen.
- Controlling the logic to decide on the next call to be taken.

Operator Profiles

In many Drinks Telesales operations an operator owns a number of customers so that a rapport may be established. It is possible to define operators to the system so that when they choose to start making calls their list is displayed to them. This can be extended so that a group of operators own a list of customers. The operator can have the authority to make a decision about their work load and the sequence in which calls are to be taken.

Buying Lists

A buying list is the list of items to be discussed with the customer during a call. It can be a short customer specific list, a specific list based on that customer's history, or at the other extreme, the full catalogue of the company's item range. Care must be taken to ensure that most of the items required are on the list,

however, if the catalogue approach is used the preparation of the call list may be protracted.

Customer Contacts

In order that the sales call can be most effective it should be made to a previously agreed, named individual or contact. Text can be added to the basic details to aid the reinforcement of the relationship.

Call Profiles

A call profile is a record that a named individual in your company should telephone a named individual at the customer to discuss a list of items. This call should be made at specified frequencies and at certain times to record details of their requirements either by taking the order quantities or recording the current stock levels. There are obviously a number of points to watch carefully:

- It is not possible to make all the calls between ten and eleven on a Monday. The calls must be smoothed over the week and day as much as possible.
- Calls must be spread evenly between operators over the course of the day.
- All operators should have a number of untimed calls to fill in the blank times.
- A customer can have more than one call profile to discuss different lists, or to allow for call patterns which are not based just on a weekly cycle.

Promotions

In general promotions are to advise or act as a reminder except when an item substitution is made. In this case the promoted item is substituted if the promotion option is taken. Care must be taken when analysing sales of the base item and the substituted item.

Reason Codes

Two character reason codes can be set up to help analyse the reason for failed calls. Care should be taken to restrict the number to less than a dozen to help operators.

Cases/Pallets Conversion

A relationship can be set up between items, cases, pallets, and customers - dictating, for each item/customer pairing, the number of cases per pallet. This overrides the conversion set up on the Item Master File in Drinks Inventory Management, for order taking purposes only.

Initial Data Set-Up

Once the additional data has been set-up you are ready to receive calls and to record orders. In order to make out-going calls it is necessary to run the call list generation procedure. This will build the list of calls to make and create a rapid reference database of the previous orders for the items on the buying list for the required customers. This can be a very large task if there are:

- A large number of customers.
- A large number of lines on the buying lists.
- A large number of orders history required.

In general the production of:

- Customers.
- Buying list lines.
- Number of weeks orders

gives the number of order lines to be built into the history. It is estimated that this could be done at about 25,000 per hour although this will vary depending upon machine size and other activity.

Installing Application Manager PTF's

Application Manager PTF's must be restored and installed as QSECOFR.



Note: To install the Application Manager PTF's the system must be in a minimum state (that is with no users or subsystems / jobs running - this is important)

Use a normal User ID to create the state then sign off and sign on as QSECOFR.

At the first screen, add in library OSLPTP1 (ADDLIB OSLPTP1 *FIRST)

Type in MNGPTF and install the PTF as normal.

Once installed, the library and PTF object can only be removed by QSECOFR. Install this PTF then sign off and sign back in as PTFOWNER for subsequent PTF's.

If the above is NOT done, PTFOWNER, being inside Application manager, will say the AM PTF is installed when it has not, as PTFOWNER is using one of the objects the PTF requires, and the system will work - but will NOT have been updated.

